

The Power of the Policy Brief

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Information overload is a chronic condition. Millions of Americans face it on a daily basis. The overload creates tremendous mental stress and often hinders rather than helps those who have to make frequent and timely decisions. No group is more acutely affected than state and federal policy makers. With the increased responsibility for formulating health policy comes the tremendous need for information about health care issues.

Health services research is often not in a readily digestible form for busy, multitasked policy makers and their staff. Good, reliable, private sector sources of information do exist but must be retrieved and synthesized into a one- or two-page summary, heavy on bullets and key data. The policy brief is a communication tool that wields great power and, if done correctly, can enhance sound and successful decision making about key and complex policy issues.

In the March-April 2002 issue of the leading policy journal, *Health Affairs*, Sorian and Baugh reported on a survey of policy makers conducted between November 2000 and January 2001. The purpose of the survey was to determine policy makers' formal and informal methods of acquiring information about policy issues. A nationwide random sample of legislators and their health staff, plus executive managers of health-related state agencies, yielded a total of 292 interviews. The results showed that policy makers are indeed overwhelmed by the volume of information they

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receive and have a strong preference for information that is concise and relevant to current debates. They likewise expressed a strong desire for electronic tools to help them identify research on specific topics (Sorian & Baugh, 2002, p. 264).

The purpose of the policy brief is to provide policy makers with a clear, succinct overview of an issue. Most policy briefs are developed with very short notice. Skill in putting together a policy brief in an expeditious manner is essential. Points to consider before one begins are the following:

- Consider the source of request. Where is the request coming from? Is the requesting party the same as the audience? Does the source already have a position on the issue to be addressed?
- Consider the problem or issue. What is the problem to answer or address?
- Consider the objective. What is your objective in writing the policy brief—provide information, give direction to make a policy direction, or support existing proposals?
- Consider the audience. Who is the primary audience the policy brief will address? What does the audience or policy maker know about the topic? Do they know more or less or about the same as you? Does the audience already have a position on the issue?
- Consider the time frame. What is the time frame for completion of the policy brief?

A useful format for the policy brief follows. It has been used in a leading graduate nursing program for the purpose of helping students develop skill in policy analysis and the reporting of health services research to policy makers.

Clear Statement of the Issue

Clearly state what problem or issue will be addressed in this policy brief. For example, if the purpose of the brief is to update the policy maker on the status of medical savings accounts (MSAs), a comprehensive definition of a MSA must be included. Most often, this would be the prevailing legal (what is in statute) or legislative (taken from the proposed bill) definition. This section should provide a clear and concise statement of the issue or problem to be addressed.

Context and Background of the Issue/Problem

This section is effectively done in bulleted format. Give the background of the issue and key points in its regulatory and legislative history. Include statistics, demographic information, and recent trends. This constitutes the heart of the policy brief and will take the greatest amount of time to complete. Take the policy maker up to the present; currency of the data is critical. Provide current references for all material cited. One may want to attach a larger study from which data are drawn. Unbiased studies, such as Government Accounting Office reports and federal and state commission reports, are reliable sources of information and well received by policy makers. Results of demonstration projects should also be listed here. In addition, readily accepted journal sources include *State Health Notes*; *Health Affairs*; *Bureau of National Affairs, Health Care Policy*; *Congressional Quarterly*; *New England Journal of Medicine*; and the *Journal of the American Medical Association*.

Key policy events relative to MSAs would include the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act of 1996, the Balanced Budget Act of 1997, and the Economic Stimulus legislation that passed in March of 2002. (The latter legislation extends the current medical savings account demonstration project through December 2003.)

Options: Pros and Cons

The political realities and dimensions of the issue are listed here. What are the actions available to the policy maker? Are current proposals under consideration? List the pros and cons of each approach, and make a recommendation based on your analysis and experience with the issue. Give the timetable for action. Talk with the press secretary or administrative assistant to make sure the option provided is consistent with the stance taken by the policy maker in the past.

In the case of MSAs, the policy maker may want to introduce legislation to expand the availability of MSAs in the health care marketplace. The analysis provided by the policy brief could be very

useful as the legislator contemplates his or her options. It may also assist the policy maker when voting on legislation introduced by others in the policy-making arena.

List Resources Used to Prepare the Policy Brief

The last step is to cite references for studies and demonstration projects, journals, newsletters, and policy Web sites used to research the issue.

Many policy makers read health policy articles on a regular basis. In fact, the survey cited previously by Sorian and Baugh (2002, p. 267) reported that 45% of those interviewed said they read five or more articles on health policy each week. However, when policy makers reach a time-critical juncture, they turn to staff to provide a

well-constructed brief on the policy issue under consideration. The policy brief is an invaluable tool that can effectively inform policy decision makers. In addition, it can translate policy research into a form that is relevant, timely, and useful to those on the front line of the policy process. Writing policy briefs is a skill that must be learned and cultivated by any nurse who works in the areas of health and public policy.

REFERENCE

Sorian, R., & Baugh, T. (2002). Power of information: Closing the gap between research and policy. *Health Affairs*, 21(2), 264-268.

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